thanked his good fortune and disguised himself to go and check on the truth of the rumour,' recorded Mirza 'Ata.

> He rode out to see the royal soldiers all resting flat out in the shade, thinking the Kabul army to be still many miles distant. The Dost then took just 3,000 of the best of his troops, rushed them forward, and quickly attacked the royal troops scattered amid the gardens before they had realised what was happening. In the heat of battle, Shaikh Shah Aghasi who at Dost Mohammad's bidding had come over to the King's side a few days earlier, threw off the mask of deceit, shouting 'The King has run away, the King has run away.' He then used the ensuing confusion to attack the royal army from within. Shuja's troops were amazed to hear the cry of defeat and to see the Shaikh busy plundering. Smoke from the guns and cannon was rolling up into the sky, as Campbell and his platoon staunchly defended their position. But the young men of Kabul were fearless . . . and rushed the gun-emplacement, wounding and capturing Campbell and taking all the artillery. Shuja's army now panicked. Soon everyone had fled and the royal army was dispersed, wandering lost in the hills and plains. The Shah, contemplating this total defeat, had no choice but to flee too.[91]

Yet again, Shuja was forced to retreat. Among the captured baggage lying strewn in the gardens of Kandahar were letters of support from Wade, proving British complicity in the failed coup. Wade tried to put a good face on it all, saying that it was a result no one could have anticipated; but it now looked more and more as if Burnes had been right about the popularity and efficiency of the Barakzais, and that Wade had all along been backing a serial loser in Shah Shuja.

The secret report drawn up at the Governor General's request to analyse the policy failure in Afghanistan summed up the position with devastating brevity. 'Shah Shuja has been engaged in a series of unfortunate attempts to regain his throne,' it stated, listing Shuja's four great defeats: the first army ambushed at the Mughal gardens of Nimla, the second frozen in the snows of Kashmir, the third blown up in Peshawar by its own exploding ammunition and now the fourth taken by surprise in the gardens of Kandahar. 'He has shown great activity and enterprise in preparing and conducting his expeditions, and great fortitude in defeat, but his personal courage has always failed at the crisis of his affairs and to this defect his misfortunes are attributed.'[92]

Even Wade was now prepared to admit that his protégé looked like a spent force. But in a private conversation with the American mercenary Josiah Harlan he nevertheless foresaw there was one thing that could yet bring his friend back into play. 'There is now no possible chance for Shuja's